11.9 The Safety Parabola

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP II 2014, Question 10

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/14-s2-q10

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself Write x and y in terms of t, and eliminate t. How can you write $\sec^2\theta$ in terms of $\lambda = \tan\theta$?

STAGE 1 Fix x, vary the angle

Ask yourself For a fixed $x > 0$, think of y as a function of λ. What kind of function is it? Which values does it take as λ ranges over all real numbers?

STAGE 2 The region

Ask yourself Through a point strictly below the curve, how many trajectories pass? And through a point on it?

STAGE 3 The furthest point

Ask yourself The furthest reachable point from O (on or above the ground) lies on the boundary. Write the squared distance $x^2 + Y^2$ as a function of x^2. Is it increasing or decreasing?

Try this next

1. **An exploding firework.** Try STEP II 2023, Question 10 (in OCR's download of the 2023 papers, www.ocr.org.uk/Images/707102-2023-past-papers.zip). It views the particles from an explosion as a sphere whose centre falls freely, and finds a particle that runs along the paraboloid of safety.

2. **Firing up a slope.** Find the maximum range of a projectile with speed u up a plane inclined at angle β. (*Hint:* where does the line $y = x\tan\beta$ meet the parabola of safety?) Show that the best angle bisects the angle between the slope and the vertical.

3. **Two angles.** Show that the two angles that reach a point P are symmetric about the bisector of the angle between OP and the vertical.

4. **The foci.** Show that the trajectory with angle θ has its focus at $(\frac{u^2}{2g}\sin 2\theta, -\frac{u^2}{2g}\cos 2\theta)$, and hence that the foci lie on a circle about O.

Further reading

- **David Morin,** ***Introduction to Classical Mechanics*** (Cambridge University Press), Chapter 3, which discusses the envelope of trajectories.
- **J. W. Bruce, P. J. Giblin & C. G. Gibson, "On caustics of plane curves"**, *American Mathematical Monthly* 88 (1981). Envelopes and caustics in geometry.
- **E. H. Lockwood,** ***A Book of Curves*** (Cambridge University Press). Envelopes, caustics and many classical curves, with constructions.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 11.9:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch11/safety-parabola.html